

Locations

Allora

The continent of Allora may be found South-west of Durenas. Boasting pristine shorelines with fine, white sand, it holds an underappreciated beauty, the majority an unspoilt paradise.

The continent is currently reachable only by a sea faring vessel and its seclusion from Durenas has led to its population swelling in pockets, hardly daring outside their safe city circles, as developed as their civilisation is becoming. The outside world is terrifying when placed alongside the familiar warmth of hearth and fire.

As the traveller ventures further inland, the softly rolling hills become mountains, reaching their craggy heads towards the cloud-spun sky above. Only the bravest of travellers have reached the peaks of these mountains and many have lost their lives along the way. The peaks are capped in snow and prone to vicious blizzards and avalanches, although if you dare chance your luck and your life, those who've gone before you have left red flags to mark their path. It is a small scrap of guidance along a path seldom succeeded.

The land mass of Allora became populated approximately one thousand five hundred years ago, although the exact date of landing is not known. Allora is controlled and led by the faction of Sylland.

Their first notable invention was the Church of the First Ray, a fantastic invention that allows them to see one another and communicate through other churches of the order where building has been completed. Demolished churches can no longer be used for this purpose. Those who maintain these churches have a penchant for pretending to be higher beings giving messages and orders to the lowly people of Allora. The common folk know little about the churches, only that they are a place of great wisdom and also fear. The fear of what may happen to them if they do not follow instructions is rife throughout the land.

To maintain this secrecy and power over the commoners and even practicing priests, those able to use the churches for their intended purpose only communicate with the few at the head of Sylland. The secret of the Church of the First Ray is known only to the top non-religious elite under the guise of bringing control, order and stability to the land. However, it is the ones in power who actually invaded the land of Allora seven hundred years ago – they took over the land from natives and claimed it for their own. And now, they guard it jealously. Control once acquired is a prize sorely relinquished.

Their philosophy in the beginning was to benefit the land, bringing peace to all corners and harmony to citizens. Over time, however, this became warped in the claws of power and control dominated, blackened fingers crawling from the pit of what once was a wholesome people. Overbearing, the leaders brand their name with peace and clasped paws, eyes piously turned up to a heaven that exists for them and only for them with their paws firmly on solid ground. They do not believe in heaven, ruled by greed, yet they preach that they are united as one against the evils of their world. Creatures classed as monsters are few and far between on Allora but the true monsters walk among the people of the land.

Durenas

Durenas is commonly referred to as 'The Plate' by those living on other continents.

Regions of Durenas

- Sylland
- Pharn
- Runegith
- Linnesse
- The Vast Desert
- Torr Har

Pharn

This kingdom is in a cold war with Sylland. Their major belief system involves the theory that all beings are bound together. Some, like family, are bound more closely. It feeds off the thought that there are invisible links between all creatures, some stronger than others. Some bonds tied too closely, in line with this theory, can never be broken.

As these ties strengthen groups, however, they can also bring infection, disease and evil. Evil is more likely to infect those closely bound, destroying whole families, but, once generated, can spread like wildfire through these ties. This is one reason that there is so much evil in this world and why it is so difficult to break free of the hold of evil once taken into its clutch. It is a vicious circle.

This is currently a theory without solid science to support it but one that is widely believed. There are many searching to disprove it while those in power and the masses perpetrate it widely.

Sylland

The original name of this kingdom was Gu Tres. It originally encompassed a slightly smaller area but has expanded over the years into other territories. It was conquered and the kingdom created after sea faring persons landed on its shores from the southern seas many hundreds of years ago, finding the new land that they were searching for at long last. The exact date of landing is unknown. Sylland is currently in a cold war with Pharn.

Around seventy percent of people in Sylland are heterosexual. While the nobles are more accepting of 'alternate lifestyles', the commoners are less so and will cast out most whose sexuality does not fit with their idea of what is right in the world. Nobles, generally, will try to ensure they have two sons. This normally allows them to be certain that at least one of them is heterosexual and able to continue the family line. Homosexual sons are not able to carry on a family line as they will not produce heirs; adoption does not allow for a pure bloodline and, while allowed, it does not produce a blood heir to the family name and lands.

While nobles are accepting of those preferring the same sex, they make little to no attempt to protect those of lesser birth, letting them fend for themselves. If an individual is unlucky enough to be born into a low class family, they will often conceal their sexuality just for the simple reason of survival. Sometimes survival trumps everything else.

Servants receive little pay but are not tied to a family or household. If they choose to, they can leave at any point but sometimes other work can be difficult to come by. If they do leave a household, it is customary for them to receive additional coin for their services. This is based on the value that the master of the household gives to their work and what he thinks of them as an individual. Although this practice is usually followed, it is no secret that it is sometimes exploited. Those desperately leaving service of a household can be forced into acts or dangerous errands before leaving in order to receive this extra coin – or even promised additional coin that never materialises. There is no real recourse for servants who have been unfairly treated. Those of charismatic masters tend to stay for many years, seeking safety in familiar and stable households.

Sylland is a spider web of heavily worn but long lasting roads that were laid many years ago. Many places may be found along the roadside but the most usual locations include inns and monasteries, the latter of which holds great importance for faith in this land. Many roadside travellers hike from town to city, including packs of monks, farmers with goods to trade, general traders, travelling healers and, of course, lone travellers. It is not advised for travellers to undertake a trek alone due to groups of bandits and highwaymen; it is an easy way to lose your life.

Borver

(City within Sylland)

Tanya's farm resides outside this city.

This city is close to the border of Pharn.

Devris

(City within Sylland)

Lord Barreth's estate is located here.

As the city is old, they rebuild over their own ruins and the city is an unusual mix of new and old buildings. The most decrepit sections are scheduled to be torn down and rebuilt as soon as the labour is acquired. The poorest live in the worst parts of the city and often have no say when they are evicted to make way for new buildings that they cannot usually afford to live in. Once evicted, they are left to fend for themselves and seek out new homes.

Devris was formerly the capital of Sylland, before it was overrun and razed two hundred years ago by the desert tribes. The tribes were not seen as an issue before this event and the kingdom succeeded in repelling them but only after the city was burned to the ground. The new capital of Sylland is Ratrine. Devris receives a lot of trade from minerals, as it is near the desert and most of its trade comes from Cherlan, which is a town on the very edge of the desert. They are also well known for their culinary ability and frequently trade non-perishable goods while travellers come from leagues around to savour the delights on offer from streets and inns.

Hundreds of years ago, when desert clans sought to invade and conquer, the city acted as a barrier to these attacks, shielding towns and cities behind it from a relentless onslaught. If Devris did not command such a strong military presence at that time, it is doubtful that the clans would not have encroached further across the continent, although it is unsure how

successful their attacks would have been. If they posed enough of a threat, it is supposed that the cities would have banded together but they remained jealous of their commodities, protecting themselves to the detriment of all else. In modern times, however, Devris is a peaceful place and there are few soldiers remaining and guards only as needed for the nobles.

It is now seen as beneficial city but not one that is tactical or entirely needed. Devris has failed to supply all that many troops for the army in recent years and those that are sent to the greater cause are thought of as weaker than the rest. Despite the past success of Devris as a military stronghold, it is inexplicably seen a place for empathetic persons, perhaps because they dealt with the desert clans more fairly with as few deaths as possible. It no longer deals with many desert troublemakers as it is shielded by Cherlan, the mineral farming town closest to the harsh desert.

A common joke is told as follows: “How do you know your warden is from Devris? The jail is empty.”

In Devris itself, there are many ruins of towers and forts, but the only ones that are functioning still are used by the city military, or what remains of it.

Lord Barreth's Estate

The estate boasts a mansion and, many years ago, used to be a highly defended keep. In the back is a large stable block and training yard for the art of sword fighting and jousting, among other pursuits. Closer to the mansion is a small chapel, exclusively maintained as a place of worship.

Ratrine

(City within Sylland)

This is the capital city of Sylland.

Timeline

Year 290

- The Peace Treaty of South-Western countries was signed.
- The countries called their fighting to an end, beginning to flourish economically and socially.

Year 430

- Religion of South-Western countries
- Created based on magic. No belief in gods, but in unity against the darkness. Magic for creation, not destruction.

Year 1000

- Magic Limiters of South-Western Countries.
- Found ways to limit the magic of rare individuals who had too much. Done for the safety of everyone.

Year 1300

- Foundation of Sylland.
- Built with Church of the First Ray as the controlling structure.
- Slaughter of natives (both monsters and the native race of Estrel).
Creation of the first churches.

Year 1700

- God-like and improvement to churches.
- The god-like are invented on the main-land through research, and then the Church of the First Ray starts to create them due to orders.
- Churches performed hidden miracles that made monsters and elves feral. It also had the effect of severely reducing magic potential throughout the country, as most magic came through the natural ones (elves/monsters, and those they mated with)
- Elves heavily turned into god-like.
- Elves fled to their natural homes where the magic draining effects were lessened.

Year 1900

- Invasion of the Desert
- Invasion into Sylland by monsters and those who lived alongside them. Trying to take back land that belongs to them. (Elves)
- Most of the monsters came from the desert, but many from within the country helped to take over Devris (capital of the time.)
- God-like used to cleanse “infested” (taken over) cities. Whole ones were levelled, regardless of number of citizens still there. Blame ended up being on the monsters for destroying the cities.
- Most leaders died when Devris was demolished. That act burned up most of the god-like, and drained most of the church’s stored power.

Year 2135

- The present

Magic and Mystique

The Workings of Magic: An Overview

When life began, so did magic. Magic was brought to the southern continents upon colonisation, trickles of magic spreading through the land like the tributaries of a river speeding towards the sea. Although life produces magic, this is in an inert form and magic covers both creatures and plants – anything of a living nature – in an invisible film. While this film denotes magical potential, it is also essential to health and general wellbeing in the physical sense, protecting against magic viruses and from unwholesome magic effects. One may be affected by magic through the natural world or deliberately by an unsavoury individual with a greater grasp of essence.

The thickness and covering of this magical film depends on the individual, which replenishes itself much like natural oils in skin and fur. The film cannot be seen by the naked eye, yet there are those in Sylland that claim to have devised scrying tools and spyglasses that allow this film to be seen. It is said that if a person is exercising their use of magic frequently, their film will appear different. If Sylland have uncovered this information, however, they are holding it close and there is no open confirmation as to what happens to the aura of magic when it is flexed or developed.

Inert magic, present in nature, can be manipulated by those with greater magical potential, although there are methods through which one can increase their magical potential and, later, their skill with magic. Like any muscle, this one can also be trained. In most cases, magic users manipulate the inert magic near them, using their mind, to change it into different forms. A fire may be started, for example, to keep a lonesome traveller warm on a sodden night with mist sweeping down the valley. Magic can keep people alive and the use of it is a skill to be cherished and honed.

The South-Western continent, populated in dense pockets around towns and cities, has learned to harvest this film to use as a commodity, although it is more of a resource to be sold to merchants than used. As it is self-replenishing, it can be an easy way to earn coin as long as you skate under the radar of Sylland, who wish to put an end to this practice. As with many things, they see it as a threat to their control and, therefore, will not tolerate it. It is a powerful resource, however, and keeps many of the poorer folk alive when times are lean.

Magic is not widely accepted by the wider population but it is the faction of Sylland that shows the greatest detest – even fear – of magic. Non-church magic is seen as false, dark magic, something dangerous that should be stamped out. Those found to be using magic or with a simple aptitude for it. They see preventing magic use before it happens as vital as culling those from the herd who are devoted to it. To Sylland, Church magic is the only way, divine calling from the gods above. Some, however, are beginning to doubt that there are even any gods at all.

How Magic is Used

The magic system comes down to two forms of energy, which are magic and essence. Both are different but, when combined, they are simply called ‘magic’. There has been little formal study into magic as a whole but most are aware of its presence and that some use it, whether under the approval of higher powers or not. Magic is a cause for much debate across the

lands.

Essence

Essence may also be called dormant magic, base magic or magical essence.

Animals naturally produce essence, which is the invisible film that clings to their bodies. Some creatures are born with an innate ability to sense and even manipulate this essence with their mind, although the talent rarely rises to the surface. Those who possess the ability are secretive about their talents for fear of discovery and becoming an outcast, whether their leaders welcome the use of magic or not. Essence may also be found on plants and some material that comes from a natural, living product. It is trickier to retain essence on something that was living but is no longer living, such as a piece of leather that came from the skin of a bovine.

Upon the ‘birth’ of a being – animal or germinated plant – essence launches into production until the being is completely covered in a skin tight shell that grows with the living creature or plant. Only when the being reaches its full size is production halted. In the case of trees, which grow for years upon years, essence may be produced indefinitely or until the tree is felled through natural or unnatural means.

If there is a break in this essence or the shell thins for any reason – potentially a magical attack – the body will produce more and more of essence until the casing is healthy again. If the body is weak or ailed, repair will be slower or may not take place naturally at all. There are some individuals that are unable to repair their essence at all, although they often fall prey to magical illnesses at a very young age and die from their lack of protection. As producing essence takes a great deal of energy from the body, it usually only works when a body is healthy and able to meet its demands.

The thickness of an essence shell varies between people but larger, more rotund individuals will have a larger surface area and, naturally, have more essence surrounding them. There is not a finite amount for each person available. As the essence shell serves as protection from magical viruses, those whose health is on the poorer end of the scale will suffer from a deteriorated shell and have a greater chance of becoming unwell, as a knock on effect.

Magic

Magic may be produced through manipulating essence. This may also be called ‘active magic’ and what is the driving force and fear behind magic use. Whereas essence is merely protective and useful as a commodity, it can be utilised to cause harm or gain and entirely in the hold of the user wielding it. Like anything else, it is a tool and a tool may be turned to uses of evil as well as good.

Sensing Essence and Magic

Some animals may be born with the ability to sense both essence *and* magic through their existing senses. It is rarer that an animal would be born with multiple sense that can sense magic, although this is certainly possible. Magic causes great disturbance in its use and is easily identifiable whereas essence is far more subtle and passive, requiring greater skill to detect. If a creature is born with the ability to manipulate essence into magic, this increases the likelihood that they will also possess a higher level of skill in sensing magic.

Senses and Magic

Sight

- Essence and magic are most commonly sensed through vision.
- Essence usually takes the form of a shimmer or sheen over the user or space in which it is being used.
- Magic is stronger and more forceful, displaying itself as a radiant glow. Its intensity correlates with the strength of the individual and essence behind it.
- The colour or shading of the effect depends on the individual. There have been few studies into this phenomenon so not much is known – more extensive research would have to be undertaken in order to learn more.
- One who can sense magic in this way could be blinded temporarily or permanently if they look directly at a mass of concentrated magic or, in rarer cases, essence.

Hearing

- This is not as common as sight but a relatively frequent notion amongst those with the ability to sense essence and magic.
- Essence is usually heard as a faint hum, though there are whispers that it resembles a large mass of crickets. It may resemble a swarm when particularly powerful: this, however, is a rare occurrence.
- Magic often takes the form of a series of grinding pulses or one continuous scrape, like a horseshoe over stone.
- Hearing essence and magic is relatively harmless. A large amount may block hearing for a while and cause ringing in the ears but it is not known to destroy hearing entirely.

Smell

- Essence and magic both smell unique and smell is an easy way to distinguish between the two, if one possesses the ability. Neither smell particularly pleasant or unpleasant and the scent received will differ between people.
- If one is close to the source of magic or there is a particularly powerful source, it is more likely to emanate an unpleasant odour, which has been said to be similar to sulphur.
- As is the case with most of the senses, the smell of magic tends to overpower the smell of essence except in exceptional circumstances. Essence would have to be strong and completely pure for it to match the aroma of magic in use.
- Tracking magic through scent can be a very useful skill and more animals are known to have this ability, if not the sense to best utilise it if they are of the four-legged non-sentient kind. Traces of magic can linger as scents clinging to vegetation and so on, which is how it may be tracked by a skilled user.

- The smell of magic may be overwhelming enough to make someone vomit or need to leave the area. It has never been proven to be dangerous.

Touch

- This is the only sense with which it is easier to detect essence than magic.
- As essence is manipulated into magic, it can be difficult to pin down with touch – sometimes there are exceptions such as when an object is infused with magic.
- By touching another living being, one with this ability would be able to sense the strength and health of another's essence. This can be used to assist those who may have a weakened essence and therefore more susceptible to magical viruses.
- Essence is harmless to sense through touch alone.
- If tracing magic with the sense of touch, the user must be more careful, which is why this is the most dangerous sense of the five. Touching a magically infused object may burn flesh from bone, depending on the strength of the magic involved. It is advised that one exercises caution if sensing magic through touch.

Taste

- Even rarer is the ability to taste magic.
- It is rare to taste essence as most that would find its way into a creature's mouth is dead anyway and any lingering essence evaporated by the time it is served up on a clay plate. If eating live food, such as oysters from the sea, essence may, of course, be tasted.
- Essence has a subtle taste that can often be missed by the uneducated or those not specifically looking for it. Slightly bitter, one could put the odd taste down to a bad piece of food or simply something they should not be tasting in the first place.
- Magic has a sharp, metallic tang like blood in the mouth and it is not unknown for those who can sense magic through taste to become violently ill from tasting a powerful source.
- Magic will most often be transited through food and may be used to enhance the taste of the food. However, if someone who tastes the food can also sense magic in this way, the effect will not be felt and the food will taste vile. The taste depends on the combination of flavours with metallic magic, food and magic warping one another.
- The few instances in which this may be a useful ability include when a magic user is attempting to poison you through the manipulation of magic. One with this ability would do well to be excessively careful at group gatherings and feasts.

Manipulating Essence

Some sentient creatures are born with the ability to manipulate essence with their minds, though this is quite a rare ability. As magic users are scorned, hunted down and outcast – if not killed – many keep their abilities a secret so the true numbers or rarity is not known for certain. The ability to use magic does not tend to reveal itself before someone is ten years of age, although it is easily detectable through other magical means, such as the detecting of particularly powerful essence. In some cases, people may never realise that they have the ability to manipulate essence, especially if they were never born with the ability to sense essence or magic. They remain unsure whether this obliviousness is a blessing or a curse.

Manipulating magic is usually referred to as the casting of spells. This does not require any incantations; some magic users will chant to focus their minds but this is not necessary and can lead to unwelcome exposure.

Nearby essence can be manipulated into different basic forms, falling under the headings of two base types, which are material and energy. As an individual can manipulate any nearby essence, it is possible to use a crowd of people and manipulate their essence, which will replenish itself if taken for another use. Only those who can sense magic would notice the effect if conducted in a public location. It is, however, a dangerous practice and brings into question ethical implications of ‘stealing’ essence from the unknowing. The further away a target resides, the less effect essence manipulation is.

The material type requires a lot more essence to manipulate than the energy type but less mental control in order to be successful. Due to this, it is sensible for a magic user to have material on hand to utilise without having to create it from scratch with essence. This will generate a great deal more magic and be easier to detect, however.

The energy type takes less essence than the material type but requires more mental control due to its volatility. This manner of magic use is prone to accidents and, sometimes, even death.

Once something, material or energy, has been changed into a strictly magical form, it cannot be changed back. There is nothing that may currently reverse this process.

Essence shells tend to protect against the energy forms of magic, so it would be hard to make someone's blood boil without first stripping them of their essence. It would be a longer process to kill someone using energy in this way and one would likely be uncovered and the casting of the spell halted swiftly. Material forms may cut through shells of essence depending on what they are and how they are used as it is a highly varied field.

It is common practice to use multiple forms of magic simultaneously to produce the desired effect. Skilled users, however, often do not require this but it is something that takes many years of study. In a world where magic use is dubious at best and carries the death penalty at worst, few can reach this level even with innate natural skill.

Material forms of magic: a non-exhaustive list

- Water
- Earth
- Air

Energy form of magic: a non-exhaustive list

- Light
- Heat
- Mechanical
- Gravitational
- Electrical
- Sound
- Chemical
- Kinetic

Combining forms

Material and energy forms of magic may be combined, which is the most common use of magic.

Example: ice (water and heat)

To create ice, the magic user would infuse existing water with the lower end of the heat form (cold) – this is the simplest method known at present. Alternatively, for a more skilled user, one could create the water and apply the cold form to it at the same time, resulting in ice. This magic would be easily detectable on a larger scale as ice, of course, cannot simply appear. Those practicing often form cubes of ice in clay cups to retain their anonymity the best they can.

Ice may also be used as a weapon and is versatile as a weapon.

Ice in use as a weapon

Ice may be formed into shards in the process of creation (please see above) and shot at another person. In years past, combat mages were briefly utilised in battle using similar tactics, although the practice has fallen out of fashion with the distrust of magic.

To create these frozen weapons, a mage would create ice but with the colder version of the heat energy form infused specifically to form icicles. This requires a greater level of skill and control, as the icicles could not be allowed to melt before their use.

The icicles, once created, would be infused with the form of kinetic energy, to promote and control movement within a limited range. The icicles can then be moved closer to the magic user, if further away, to make the task easier as it is simpler to use magic when the object is closer. More magic may be poured into nearer objects and kinetic energy may be built up in the icicles so that they may be launched towards a target, whether living or not. Outside a certain range, a magic use would not retain control due to the distance but this range can slowly be expanded through strenuous practice and gradually building of personal skill.

Essence Stockpiles

Some magic users have concocted methods to safely move essence without converting it into magic and therefore have been able to create stockpiles of essence within materials (see section on material forms) and/or objects.

While most stockpiles are kept small and mobile to boost a magic users available essence for specific tasks, these stockpiles expire swiftly and usually last only one week before they begin to degrade. This stockpile of essence would be suitable for preparing before travel to take essence with the traveller in case they run into trouble. If they were embarking on a longer expedition, they may have to stop to replenish their stockpile halfway through their journey, which can be dangerous if there are bandits on the road besides natural predators. Some say that there are ways to preserve stockpiles in order to make them last longer, but this is not common knowledge.

The higher quality stockpiles tend to use a life form as a base. Rare magical plants are often used as they produce enough essence to be manipulated without killing the plant when it is used to stockpile essence. The natural magic in this flora also assists in slowing the degradation of essence, although they will naturally produce less essence themselves. Magical flora is difficult to come by and reserved only for those of the highest status, unless one lowers themselves to the ranking of a common thief. Most magical plants require higher temperatures to survive and are kept near hot springs where the natural heat of the spring warms a clay building where they are housed. If they are too close to the desert or out in the open, they are easy targets for theft so most plants are kept secluded away for the rich to admire.

Magical trees are harder to keep and can be used to stockpile much more essence at one time, proving exceptionally resilient to the act. These are only used by the civilizations on the south-western continent, which have studied the practice more in the name of selling essence. It is difficult to identify magical trees as they conceal their true nature as an act of self-defence and protection so a magic user could have one planted beside their home with no one else being any wiser to their true intentions. Magical trees are more commonly found in moderate climates and do not do well in extreme heat or cold.

The design and creation of these stockpiles requires many precise calculations for them to form in the correct fashion and not simply explode in the magic users face. There have been many deaths in relation to the creation of stockpiles as such a large store of magic can sometimes be exceptionally volatile. It depends entirely on the competency of the mage and the time they have spent honing their skill. The type of essence being stored has to be factored into consideration also and the total amount being stored. The more essence there is, the more difficult it is to contain.

Factions

The Church of the First Ray

This faction is composed primarily of healers, who are known throughout the land for their skill and devotion to the faith. Most of the churches can be found in cities and towns. Where there are more people, more churches can be found. It is very rare to find a church from this faction in the middle of nowhere, although there are the entrepreneurial that believe more can be converted further afield and new towns formed. These brave souls are infrequently successful and are mocked as fools for even attempting such an endeavour in the name of faith. It is seen as a pointless folly to venture further afield to recruit followers and most, especially healers, are encouraged to stay in the heart of cities so that as much of their faith as possible can be observed.

The church survives mostly on donations and those in high positions often call the general population to the churches in order to perform holy miracles before a large group for these donations. They put on a performance, spinning and throwing their hands in the air to draw in the crowd – the effect is almost hypnotising to the observant watcher. It is unsure how many of these acts are a true representation of any healing skill or power these followers have, yet the coin continues to flow and the church thrives. Magic is used but the church claims that this is the only true magic and used for a holy cause. It is accepted at this present time but only for the means of religion, which seems understandable when explaining something that most people cannot sense at all. It is beyond their understanding and so is any higher power of creation or destruction, so it only makes sense that they go together.

The Church of the First Ray created the Reborn or Redeemed, who are individuals ‘blessed’ enough to be overloaded with magic (see Reborn/Redeemed). If a raven appears during the ceremony, the rite is deemed a failure and the individual who put themselves forward for redemption is either cast out or killed. Ravens are not often seen on the continent, being known as a bird of ill omen and slaughtered by anyone who comes across them. They have always been hated, although no one can tell where the hate originally stemmed from. Either way, it does not matter to the church any more what happens to them as the donations will flow in as the crowd only sees that evil-doers are kept away from its apparently pristine foundations.

There are few in the church that are malicious and most actually believe they are doing the lord’s bidding, although they are, unfortunately sadly mistaken and misled. Those in power, as is so often the case, use their devoted followers to further their cause and grab for power. Power is as good as currency in these times and the poor souls at the foot and heel of the church are the ones who truly suffer.

The Miracles

The miracles performed are a combination of science and magic. They are only officially performed in their churches, aside from the Reborn/Redeemed exemptions. There is nothing, however, to restrict the followers use of magic as long as it is used for a holy purpose. This is a lenient, lax rule that makes it difficult to convict anyone of the faction for using dangerous magic.

Unlike essence stockpiles, the churches are built and designed with a specific type of stone that retains magic well, allowing the power of it to be stored within the churches. The very

purpose of the churches was originally to generate, harvest and store magic for the further of those in power.

Some people consider the churches a sham due to how they beg for money – performing for donations like common street performers – and also how they congregate in the most populated areas. People think that they would expand their range if they were truly interested in spreading the word of god. However, like moths to a flame, they cannot resist the allure of the unknown and flock to the churches to watch the miracles being performed for the lowly price of a coin or two, if they can spare it.

Reborn/Redeemed

These individuals can be referred to as godlike. Within the church, they are called the Reborn or Redeemed and the church itself believes it is a blessing of the highest order to be Reborn. It is only usually followers of many years – never ones in the most power, however – that are chosen to be Reborn and there does not appear to be any outwardly logical reason for them being chosen. Those on the inside have methods through which they can measure their magical latency and make decisions on who to Redeem based on this, although it is a process that carries a high risk.

A Reborn ceremony is one of the miracles that the church invites folk to watch as they impress a vast amount of magical power, stored in the church's walls and foundations, into the chosen individual. This overloads both their body and mind, changing them irrevocably in mental and physical appearance, and allows them to give out orders. There is an element of fear with these godlike individuals as it is said that only the strongest of mind can resist the urge to obey their orders, making them a powerful force within the church walls and, it is rumoured, in the military also. This is unconfirmed and not something that the church, if true, would like to become public knowledge as it is hardly in line with their faith and the image they are promoting.

It is only known that there needs to be a certain amount of latent magical capacity or potential for this 'miracle' to prove a success, otherwise the individual will die from the inside out as the magic swallows them whole. If an individual is lucky when the magic does not hold, it will simply seep away, barely noticed as it goes but the loss of it forever felt in the person's soul. Only a few individuals have ever successfully completed the ceremony and survived the massive influx of magic, their very bodies becoming a store. As only few have ever survived, it is difficult for the population as a whole to see them as a threat, only of good use to a church they still want to believe is wholesome and good. Regardless of the person's magical potential, if a raven appears during the ceremony, the whole thing will be called to a halt and the individual cast out of the church. In many cases where the ceremony has failed as a result of this ill omen, the person undergoing the miracle will be stoned to death by the crowd. The church sees this as a necessary sacrifice to uncover who is truly worth of being Reborn.

While the Redeemed contain a large concentration of magical energy, they are directly linked to the church where they were created. If the church's magical foundation is destroyed, this link is lost. This is vital to the Reborn individual's wellbeing and is why they are known to protect their churches piously, carefully directing away those who seek to cause harm to the church itself with a quiet word that cannot be missed by the ears it is intended for. Without the continuous flow of magic through this link between the church and the Reborn, the magical power will, in the best case scenario, go stale and become useless to the carrier. In a

far more dangerous case, it warps into a highly reactive state, which can manifest in vicious explosions or strange phenomena akin to natural disasters.

Most people know that they represent the church, they find it difficult to believe their strength when the church itself appears little more than a street performance to an undiscerning eye. They know that this 'ceremony' creates the Reborn, as they are invited to watch, but it has become known as something to weed out evil roots from civilisation. It is a fairy tale to most to consider the Reborn to be godlike in anything. As their appearance also changes, whether in aura or physical look, when one is Redeemed, it is difficult to match up the past person to the Redeemed, further separating them from anything known.

Reborn can determine the truth of statements.

They are known for being able to read minds and are treated with great caution, when seen in public, because of this. They are quite reclusive, however, so, if you are lucky enough to meet a Reborn in person, you would do well to ask as many questions of them as possible. No one likes the thought of another being able to tell their most intimate emotions and it is not certain how much discretion the Redeemed employ in the use of this blessed skill. Without the certainty that they will be respectful, few dare get close even though there is no information about how close another person has to be in order for this skill to be used.

Like others in the church, they perform miracles but do not restrict themselves to the church. The occasions on which they do venture further afield are often to perform these miracles and attract more crowds and donations, displaying the might and power of the church. This purpose could be said to conflict with the church's values but few dare speak up. The Reborn keep this skill as quiet as possible, preferring to use it when it most benefits them. If too many are openly aware and conscious, in general conversation, that they are able to read their partner in conversations mind, they often become uncomfortable. Reborn require socialisation just like any other fur, although this can be difficult to come by when they are revered and feared.

Reborn do not feel pain, unusually. Little is known about this phenomenon, although those within the church have put the Reborn through rigorous tests to feel the true extent of this. On occasions where the church that they are tied to has been attacked, they have proven that they are able to sense pain or at least notice it through the attack on the church (or themselves, if they are targeted) and have moved to warn the church. When their church is under attack – this is a very rare occurrence as too many citizens equally fear and are in awe of the church – they will do absolutely anything they can to stop it. The only thing that they seem to hold back from is self-sacrifice as they hold their lives in high regard. This is perhaps a side-effect of being told how important they are and held in positions of great respect within the church, giving them an inflated sense of self-importance. The longer one lives as Reborn, the more likely they are to believe themselves of greater importance than anyone else. They are fed this lie on a daily basis.

The few Reborn that have perished have experienced great pain right at the point of death, however, and it is assumed that the pains of a lifetime cumulate once their lifespan comes to an end. It can only be supposed to be a truly horrific end, although there always seems to be another willing to stand trial by fire in the ceremony to see if they are strong enough and worthy enough of being Redeemed. Unusually, there always seems to be another Reborn to take the place of one that has died. There has been some speculation about why this is but no

definite answer to the question. Perhaps the magical potential shifts to another, allowing them to step forward and take their rightful place as Reborn, ascending to a status akin to godlike. Or maybe there is simply an elaborate scheme to remove Redeemed once they become too powerful for the church's liking. There are many theories and the church does all it can to keep these scandalous thoughts and suggestion under wraps.

Their strength and vitality is vastly different – increased – from that of a normal person. By way of an example, they are able to run further at a quicker rate than any other person known on the continent, tiring rarely. Their essence is stronger to those able to sense essence also and able to support them through many a difficult and treacherous situation. The magical energy in them seems to place a high priority on keeping them alive and they heal swiftly from any injuries with the aid of the magic that was pumped into them at the ceremony, constantly replenishing itself as long as the host is kept healthy and linked to their church.

They are not invincible, however, and can be killed. They are more difficult to kill due to not feeling pain. Although pain and injury will slow them down or put them at a massive disadvantage, they will not stop fighting until the light disappears from their eyes and death overcomes them. They are formidable enemies.

The Life of Reborn

Reborn are frequently used as arbiters of justice for high priority cases in return for donations to the church, which is always seen as a worthy cause to undertake in the church's eyes. This is widely known to the general population and the one time that those who refuse to enter the walls of the church

They are used as messengers, sending messages in person or via magical communication to other kingdoms as they can either travel far more swiftly than other people or can secretly transfer shorter range messages. Some have suggested that this is a mind-link skill with other Reborn who have been placed in other kingdoms for this very purpose, some as spies. This is not certain, most probably to maintain the safety of any Reborn away from their churches.

Redeemed can be used as siege instruments as they can perform massive feats of magic and strength in the field. They prefer these acts to be referred to as miracles. This knowledge is kept close to the church and those in positions of power. Since many who go into battle do not return and those who do are often shell shocked by the experience and few believe their stories of battle and war. There are tales of powerful Reborn wiping out entire battlefields with their magic, leaving only commanders stood back from the lines of fighting with no one left to fight for them. In battle, they are ruthless and often operate with as little concern for those fighting on the same side as them as those who strive to cut them down. Their only concern is survival so anyone that wants to stay alive had best stay well back from the fighting and their wrath.

In rare instances of dire need, they are used as assassins. Their skills lend well to skilled assassination and there are no known instances of them being detected when they are hired, through the church, to deal with enemies. The church handles this aspect of 'business' as it leads to a lot of money of the church – donations cannot truly compare to this line of work. Some Reborn think themselves above this work and undertake it only with great derision and loathing for the act of assassination. As much as they like to show off their powers when

provided the opportunity, they do not consider themselves to be hired workers for something as vile as killing a single target. No, this is below them, undoubtedly.

As powerful as Reborn are, they tend to be well guarded by elite warriors as they hold so much power and, having taken so much power from others in the church, they are an incredible investment. As self-important as the Reborn behave, this is also with due cause as they are some of few that boast the abilities they do. They are all powerful and there are different levels of Reborn, with some acquiring greater power than others. One Reborn, if powerful enough, could take on every other one on the continent. There is yet to be a Redeemed with this much power, however, or at least so much power that they will brag of this openly. A smarter Reborn may secret this hidden talent away until an opportune moment or simply live their lives the best they may under the circumstances.

Not every Reborn is happy with their lot in life.

The Temple Elite

The Temple Elite are the most powerful fighters the church holds. They may have little magical ability or a great deal of it but they are formidable opponents either way. Their main purpose is to defend the church and the Reborn. For this reason, they may never venture very far from the church itself once they are enlisted, unless their designated Redeemed needs to travel in order to fulfil their assigned duties. Few are happy with this arrangement and yearn for more fertile grounds where their skills may be tested on something other than a practice court at the back of the church. They train daily and their regime is ruthless, designed to keep them in peak form at all times. Many look to land themselves with a travelling Reborn, though these assignments are few and far between.

Templars of the Spire

This faction is located in Pharn and directly opposes The Church of the First Ray as they devote their lives to magic. Far from fearing magic, they welcome it and operate on an equal level to train each other in magic. There is no struggle for power within the faction. Their only goal is to become more and more powerful, controlling their magic so that it does not become a threat to others.

Everyone in the kingdom who has an aptitude for magic is required to train with them – much like being enlisted into a military force – so that they. People from other kingdoms will travel to Pharn for the sole purpose of controlling their magic. Even if they do not want to live on Pharn, controlling their magic is essential to remaining undetected and living long, happy lives. Detection in most locations leads to death as fear of magic spreads far. Some choose to stay longer on Pharn to take advantage of this training, which does not come at the cost of any coin, and spend a large portion of their lives honing their magical skill.

Their focus is on combat training and pure magic training – combat training possesses a magical twist, of course, and brings together multiple forms of magic to best place a mage to defend themselves or fight for their kingdom. It is rare that these battle mages make it into battle, however, and it is perhaps due to this rarity that this faction is unconcerned about them taking magic back to their homeland and going to war against Pharn. With so many loathing magic, it would be a great leap to imagine another kingdom actively using magic against them, aside from the Reborn in The Church of the First Ray, who are another story entirely.

Templars of the Spire seek to defend themselves from the Church of the First Ray, against whom they would be hopelessly outmatched if a Reborn was to take them on. Inherent magical potential and ability cannot currently match what a Redeemed has available to them but they can be slowed down or driven away, which is all that Templars of the Spire strive to do if the worst happens. Protection of their own and their lands is all they aim for and their intentions are good and pure.

The faction behaves much like a church in the sense that magic almost becomes a way of life and faith with the students and teachers spending their whole lives under its wing in some cases. Many say that magic is the only higher power, the power without explanation in the world, and is to be cherished, not hidden away or feared. Where it is revered, magic is also treated with respect as it has the potential to kill as much as any sword or spear in the wrong hands. It is a tool and one that can be repurposed to cause great harm and death in the worst circumstances.

Uncontrollable magic – most often seen in the hands of those with the most magical potential – is also a force to be reined in and Templars of the Spire are firm yet just in their handling of those who deny their help, choosing instead to ignore their magic and let it run wild. It is said that they are able to block the magic of those who truly do not wish to use it for personal reasons or the views held within their kingdom towards magic. This is unconfirmed but there have been fewer and fewer cases of uncontrolled magic imploding on unfortunate souls since Templars of the Spire have gained strength.

Members of Templars of the Spire are normally called Brothers and Sisters of the faction, lending the faction a more familiar, casual feel than The Church of the First Ray.

They are sometimes hired out to complete missions, although their beliefs do not allow them to kill unjustly. If their kingdom is at war and they deem it necessary to go to war to protect their loved ones and their kingdom, Templars of the Spire will join common soldiers on the battlefield. They prefer completing missions to going to war, however, as there is less risk as to the loss of life. Like any other person, the brothers and sisters of this faction have no wish to end their lives before their natural time comes.

Any coin earned through the completion of missions given by either the rich or those in high positions of power, goes into the faction and funds training and housing an increasing number of magic users. No one profits from this coin and mages often use missions as a method through which to hone their skills, taking them into uncharted territory and situations that cannot be foreseen in a classroom environment.

They will never allow themselves to be hired as assassins, considering the very act to be an abomination that should be snuffed out. In their eyes, all deserve the right to live until proven otherwise and they are known to trial criminals to determine their fates. This directly contradicts the more popular practice of entering trial by combat or allowing a judge to determine the fate of a criminal without allowing them a say in the matter. Above all, Templars of the Spire strive to be fair.

If settled within Templars of the Spire, brothers and sisters rarely leave Pharn, finding solace in a land that welcomes magic when the remainder of the world seems to shun it. Fear is only as strong as those who perpetrate it and many have learned that Pharn is a sanctuary for magic users to live, learn and develop both their magic and themselves as people.

The True Alliance

The True Alliance is an underground, secret organisation. The name is barely known and most people on the street would not know what you meant if you mentioned the name of this faction. They are more commonly referred to as rebels when their existence is known of, though there is little consideration given to members of this faction. To most, they do not matter. Less commonly, they are referred to as Free or, sometimes, simply Vagrants. There is little respect for this faction and they are viewed as a disease that slinks through the seedy underbelly of the cities, sowing discontent wherever it is found.

As their less than pleasant names suggest, they are working to encourage the populace to rise up against lords and rulers, taking back unjustly snatched power for their own. They infiltrate powerful households and assassinate the head of the house under the cover of dark, weakening the power of coin within the kingdom. Coin means nothing when a spy can slip into your home and slit your throat without anyone being any the wiser.

This faction is led by a ferocious vixen who goes by the name of Aine. No one knows if this is her real name or not – one could only assume that it is one she took on for the purpose of remaining anonymous in her leadership of The True Alliance. In her youth, she was beaten by the master of a household while her mother watched, losing her connection to her child with every passing day. Sometimes it only takes a small act to twist a youngster to a darker path but it was only when her mother and father were murdered before her eyes that she fled from the estate with the hounds of hell at her heels. Now, Aine seeks revenge and justice for all who have been treated unfairly by those in power. She wants to make her mother's death and her father's death have some meaning. She returned to kill that lord when she was strong enough and slipped his own rapier into his heart. She took joy in his death rattle. Or at least this is the story she tells.

The True Alliance viciously oppose The Church of the First Ray and loathe everything they stand for. Whereas they will scrounge and scrap and fight underhandedly for any coin they can get their hands on, they do not believe that magic should be used as a performance and are well aware of what the coin earned by The Church of the First Ray goes to. They are deeply suspicious of Reborn and more than one member of The True Alliance has fallen foul of Reborn. Finding their way to an untimely death in the hands of a god is not the way that anyone wants to go but, conversely, they believe that it is a great honour to die in service of The True Alliance. They believe in their cause very strongly and seek to right the injustices of the world.

They have a strong hold in the north as the lords moved their homes south over time, finding trade and climate to be more favourable on the south side of the continent. This faction sees this as a great success, although the lords claim aloofly that their moving south had nothing to do with The True Alliance pushing them out. The truth of this is debatable and your answer will depend on exactly who you ask. In the north, they are more prosperous and working to pull together as many cities and towns as possible to take power – by force, if necessary.

They stand only against Sylland and do not fear attack by Pharn. If anyone was to side with The True Alliance, it would be Templars of the Spire. As Templars of the Spire are notoriously difficult to drag into disputes, however, it is unlikely to ever find them on the same side when it comes to war. The True Alliance have a penchant for fighting and do not

shy away from conflict. Some would say that they even revel in it and have lost sight of the true reason why they are fighting.